

keen interest in his son's upbringing, educating him at home. Under his guidance, Hector developed an abiding love for classical literature and culture.

Conflicting paths

Hector's education was wide-ranging, but it was geared to preparing him for the medical profession, so music had a minor role. The boy learned to play his father's flageolet (a woodwind instrument) and was given some lessons on the flute and the guitar. Unusually for a composer, he had no formal training on the piano and was never particularly proficient on any instrument, although he did become a very fine conductor. With typical bullishness, Berlioz chose to put a positive spin on this. He believed that he had been "saved from the tyranny of keyboard habits, so dangerous to thought, and from the lure of conventional harmonies." Instead, it would be the orchestra that formed the basis of his compositional outlook.

"... characteristics of my music are **passionate** expression, **intense** ardor, **rhythmical** animation, and **unexpected** turns."

HECTOR BERLIOZ, MEMOIRS, 1865

Hector worked hard, earning the grades he needed for admission to medical school. He managed this in spite of the distractions of falling in love. Throughout his teenage years, he was obsessed with a girl in the neighborhood, Estelle Duboeuf, who was seven years his senior.